

GYM BUDDIES

The workout coach who took my girlfriend



EVAN
SLATE

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girlfriend

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PMI

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CONTENTS

[Title Page](#)
[Copyright](#)
[Chapter 1](#)
[Chapter 2](#)
[Chapter 3](#)
[Chapter 4](#)
[Chapter 5](#)
[Chapter 6](#)
[Chapter 7](#)
[Chapter 8](#)
[Chapter 9](#)
[Chapter 10](#)
[Chapter 11](#)
[Chapter 12](#)
[Chapter 13](#)
[Chapter 14](#)
[Chapter 15](#)
[Chapter 16](#)
[Chapter 17](#)

CHAPTER 1

I came through the door with my work backpack bouncing against my hip, my hardhat clipped to the strap clanking with each step. Tuesday. Another ten-hour shift at the distribution center, moving pallets, loading trucks, the same rotation I'd done for three years. My shoulders ached and my hands smelled like diesel. I wanted a shower, something to eat, maybe to collapse on the couch with Tara and not think for a few hours, play a game.

I came into the living room and stopped.

A man sat on our couch. I could only see the back of his head, close-cropped hair, broad shoulders that seemed to fill the entire frame of our secondhand loveseat. He was talking, his voice deep and easy, and Tara was responding in a way that made me tilt my head, trying to place the sound.

She was laughing. Not the polite, small laugh she used at work functions or when my mom told the same stories at Sunday dinner. This was different. Bigger. Her hands moved as she talked, gesturing, and her voice had a brightness to it.

The door clicked shut behind me.

Tara's head whipped around and her face lit up in a way that would have felt good if it hadn't been so clearly about something that wasn't me. She sprang up from the chair.

"Babe! You're home!" She grabbed my arm and pulled me toward the living room. "This is Andre. He just moved into that basement apartment!"

The man stood, unfolding from the couch and continuing to unfold until I realized how large he was. Not fat, not bulky in the way of someone who just lifted weights without purpose, but solid and athletic. His skin was a warm brown, his features mixed in a way that made him hard to place. He wore a fitted t-shirt that showed the definition in his arms, athletic shorts, running shoes that looked expensive. When he smiled, even I was awed.

"Stuart, man, good to meet you." He extended his hand.

I shifted my backpack and took his hand. His grip was firm, warm, confident.

"Hey," I managed, confused about what was going on here.

Tara was already talking, the words tumbling out in a rush. "So I was doing laundry downstairs, right? And you know that empty room next to the laundry room, the one that's just concrete and has all those weird pipes?"

I nodded. I knew it. We'd looked at it when we first moved in two years ago, wondered what it was for, who got murdered in there, then forgot about it.

"Well Andre's been turning it into a gym! Like, an actual gym, with weights and everything. The landlord doesn't even care. And I was just looking, you know, curious, and he saw me and he just started explaining what all the equipment was for and giving me tips on form and, Stuart, he's a personal trainer! A professional coach! And he said I could use it whenever I want! For free!"

Her eyes were bright and excited. I tried to remember the last time I'd seen her this excited about something.

Andre laughed, a big, easy rumble that filled our small living room. "She's selling it. I just pointed out a few things. But yeah, man, I've been building it out down there. Got a good deal on some equipment from a gym that was closing. Figured why pay for a membership when I could just make my own space, you know?"

"That's cool," I said, and but words were flat coming out of my mouth.

"And I was telling Tara she should come by. I mean, if she's interested. It's there." He looked at her with something in his expression that seemed encouraging, warm. "You mentioned you'd been thinking about getting in shape, right?"

Tara nodded, almost bouncing on her toes. "I have. I mean, I've been wanting to, but gym memberships are so expensive and I never know what to do anyway and then I feel so stupid..."

"Nah, everybody starts somewhere." Andre waved his hand in a way that dismissed her concern. "That's what I do, you know? Coach people. It's not about where you start. It's about showing up." He turned to me. "I always say, getting in shape is more about this," he touched my head, "than this," he touched my hip.

They talked for another minute about workout schedules and the best time to come down when he could guide her. I stood there with my

backpack still on, feeling the weight of the tools press into my shoulders. My mind was working, overthinking, the way it always did, but nothing I thought translated into words I could say. What would I even say? This guy seems too friendly? Your laugh sounds different around him? I don't like how big he is? All of it sounded insane.

Andre checked his phone. "I should get going. Got a client at six." He looked at me again with that easy smile. "Good meeting you, Stuart. Tara's lucky to have a guy who works as hard as you do." He slapped my stomach.

Tara walked him to the door and I watched them from the hallway. The size difference was striking, she barely came up to his chest. He was maybe six-two, six-three, and Tara was five-four in shoes. Next to him, she looked even smaller, more delicate, like a flower bending in wind standing next to him.

At the door they made vague plans about tomorrow, maybe, or Thursday, whenever she wanted to come down. Andre reached out in a gesture that seemed casual at first, but tucked a few strands of her long hair behind her ear. His fingers brushed her cheek and lingered for just a fraction of a second.

His eyes came up and found mine down the hall over Tara's shoulder.

"Your girl's super hot," he said, not leering or creepy, just stating it as a fact the way you might comment on the weather, easy and friendly.

Tara squealed and laughed with her hand flying up to her mouth. Then she caught herself, glanced back at me, and the laugh faded into something more nervous.

Andre grinned, gave a little wave, and left. The door closed.

Tara came back down the hall and wrapped her arms around me, pressing her face to my chest. I could smell her scent fresh and clean, just showered.

"He's so nice!" She pulled back to look up at me. "This could be really good for me, you know? I've been wanting to do something, and it's right downstairs, and it's free, and he really knows what he's doing..."

"Yeah," I said. "Seems like a good setup."

"He's just friendly, you know?" She was watching my face, reading something there she wanted to address before it became a thing. "One of those people who's probably like that with everyone." She pulled her hair out from behind her ear and shook her head. "There! He doesn't mean anything by it."

She squeezed my arms, her expression earnest now, her eyes locked on mine.

"He's just a friend," she said in a low, soft voice.

I nodded and kissed her forehead, told her it was fine, that it was great she'd have use of this gym, that it would be good for her, and it would be, of course it would be.

I let her go and headed to the bedroom to change out of my work clothes. I sat on the edge of the bed for a minute, unlacing my boots. The way he'd touched her hair. The way she'd laughed like a girly. The way he'd looked at me while doing it, like he was including me in some joke, or making sure I saw it.

I didn't know why it bothered me and I couldn't find the words to shape the feeling into something I could say. It was just a neighbor being friendly, just Tara being excited about something new.

I pulled off my boots and left them by the bed, then went to take a shower. The feeling stayed with me under the hot water, clinging to my skin like the smell of the warehouse that never quite washed away, either.

CHAPTER 2

Over the next week, Tara started going down to Andre's gym. At first it was just once, then twice, then it seemed like every other evening she was pulling on new workout clothes and heading downstairs with a water bottle and her phone. I noticed but didn't say anything. What could I say?

I was moving laundry from the washer to the dryer on a Thursday evening when I first heard them in there. The basement laundry room was next to the concrete room Andre was using for his gym. Music pulsed through the hallway, something with a heavy beat I wouldn't recognize. Under it I could hear grunting, the clank of metal on metal, the sound of weights being racked.

I opened the dryer and started transferring wet clothes, but my hands slowed when I heard voices. I glanced toward the doorway of the gym room. The door was propped open with a dumbbell and I could see part of the space, rubber mats on the floor, a weight bench, a squat rack against the far wall.

Andre came into view. He was shirtless, his dark skin glistening with sweat, and I could see the full definition of his body now, shoulders that looked carved, arms that flexed and shifted as he moved, his core tight with visible muscle. He was covered in tats.

He was doing something with a barbell, loading plates onto it, and the ease with which he handled the weight made it clear this wasn't effort for him.

He looked up and saw me through the doorway.

"Stuart! Hey man!" He waved me over, his face breaking into that easy smile.

I held up the laundry basket like a shield. "Just doing laundry."

"Come check it out when you're done. Got the place looking pretty sweet."

"Yeah, I will." I turned back to the dryer, moving faster now, and that's when I heard her voice from somewhere deeper in the gym room, Tara,

laughing at something, saying something I couldn't quite make out. She was in there too. Of course she was.

I finished the laundry in a hurry, grabbed the basket, and leaned in to look. She had ear buds on, shorts and sports bra. Her back was to me but I still waved. She was doing curls, Andre now directly in front of her mirroring her curls with about ten times the weight. He lifted his chin at me and grinned.

The next evening Tara came back upstairs around seven-thirty. I was on the couch with my console playing something. She came through the door flushed and sweaty, her face pink and her hair pulled back in a ponytail that had come loose. She looked energized in a way I rarely saw her after work, like she was wired, buzzing.

"Hey!" She dropped her water bottle on the counter and came over to the couch. "That was so good. Andre showed me how to do deadlifts. My form was terrible but he's so patient, you know? He just keeps explaining it until it clicks."

"That's good," I said.

"And he's so strong, Stuart! Like, I knew he was strong, but watching him lift is insane. He makes it look so easy. He could lift my whole body over his head no problem," she laughed. She was talking with her hands, animated. "He said I've got good natural strength in my legs, that I should focus on lower body stuff for a while. Build a foundation."

"Makes sense."

She waited, like she wanted me to ask more, but I didn't know what to ask. After a moment she smiled and kissed the top of my head. "I'm gonna shower. You want dinner after?"

"Sure."

She disappeared into the bathroom and I heard the water start. I sat there with my game on, screen dimmed from inactivity, and tried to figure out why I felt the way I felt. There wasn't anything wrong. She was working out. It was healthy. Andre was helping her. He's a friend, that's all this was.

Two days later I was coming up the stairs after work, boots heavy on the steps, and I heard voices above me. I looked up and saw them coming down from the third floor, Andre and Tara, side by side. His hand was on her lower back, fingers spread just above her waistband, guiding her down the steps.

"Gotta be careful," he was saying to her about something in the gym, no doubt. "Don't want to get caught cheating," he said with a laugh, and she turned to him and laughed too with bulging eyes. "No!"

His hand remained on her as they came down toward me. When they reached the landing where I was standing, Andre looked up and his face opened into that warm, easy smile.

"Stuart! How's it going, man?"

"Good," I said, stepping to the side to let them pass.

He squeezed my shoulder nearly too hard. "We were just heading down for a session. Tara's been killing it this week." He glanced at her and she beamed up at him. "She's got natural athleticism, man. Just needed an outlet."

Tara's face glowed at the compliment. "I'm just doing whatever he tells me," she shrugged.

"That's the secret," Andre said. "Trust the process." He patted her back, his hand warm and familiar there, and they continued past me down the stairs.

I stood for a moment, then continued up. At the next landing I stopped and turned, looking down through the gap in the railing. I could see the tops of their heads, Andre's hand still resting on her back as they descended together, their conversation fading as they reached the basement level.

That night in bed, Tara was on her phone next to me, scrolling through something that made her face glow blue in the dark room. She turned the screen toward me.

"Look at this. Andre sent me this Insta. This woman posts all these workout tips and form checks. She's amazing."

I glanced at the screen, a woman in athletic wear demonstrating a squat, her form perfect and controlled.

"Do you think I should try this?" Tara asked, scrolling to another video. "Andre said I should work on my hip mobility. This looks like it would help."

"I don't know," I said. "If he thinks so."

"He knows what he's doing with my body I think." She kept scrolling, her thumb moving across the screen. "I'm so glad he moved in. It's like having a personal trainer for free. Do you know how much people pay for this kind of attention?"

I made a sound that might have been agreement.

She set her phone down and curled against me, her head on my chest, her hand resting on my stomach. "I'm really happy," she said, and her voice was soft and content. Within minutes her breathing slowed and she was asleep.

I lay in the dark, her weight warm against me. Over the past week I'd noticed things, small things that individually meant nothing but together formed a pattern I couldn't ignore. The way she did her hair now before going downstairs, not just pulling it back, but making sure it looked good. The way she chose her workout clothes more carefully, holding up two sports bras to compare them in the mirror. The way her whole face changed when she talked about the sessions, about what Andre taught her, about his patience and his strength and his knowledge.

But what was I supposed to say? That I didn't like her working out? That I didn't want her talking to the neighbor? That her excitement bothered me?

None of it made sense. Andre was friendly every time I saw him. He always included me, always asked how I was doing, always talked about Tara's progress like it was something we were both invested in, like we were a team.

Everything was innocent. Everything was fine. I just couldn't figure out why it didn't feel that way.

CHAPTER 3

The gym sessions became routine. Every Monday, Wednesday, Friday evening, and sometimes Saturday mornings. Tara would pull on her workout clothes, check her hair in the mirror, and head downstairs with her water bottle. She started coming back later, sessions that began as forty-five minutes stretched to an hour, then longer. I stopped asking about it.

Saturday morning we went to the café on Brennan Street, the one with the mismatched furniture and local art covering every wall. The place smelled like espresso and acoustic guitar played through speakers mounted in the corners. We sat at our usual table by the window.

Tara was telling me about something that happened at work, some issue with a shipment from Taiwan, when the bell above the door chimed and Andre walked in.

He saw us immediately and his face lit up. "No way! Hey guys!"

Tara turned in her chair and waved. "Andre! Hi!"

He came over and gestured at the empty chair at our table. "You mind?"

"Of course not!" Tara said, and he pulled the chair around so he was sitting next to her, across from me.

"This place is great, right?" He took a sip of his coffee and settled in like he'd been planning to meet us here all along. "I just found it last week. Way better than the Starbucks by the gym."

We talked about the neighborhood, about the other cafés and bookstores, about the little gallery down the block that was showing local photographers.

Andre dominated the conversation but in a way that felt natural, like he was just enthusiastic about everything. When he made a point about the neighborhood gentrifying, his hand landed on Tara's shoulder for emphasis. When she was talking about the bookstore she liked, he reached out and brushed her hair back from her face so he could see her better.

"You've got that classic great bone structure," he said, studying her face like he was assessing a sculpture. "Really strong jawline. That's genetic."

You can't train that. Doesn't she Stuart?"

Tara's face went pink and she laughed, ducking her head.

Then Andre was standing behind her, his hands on her shoulders, and Tara made a small sound of surprise. "You're always so tight here," he said, his thumbs working into the muscles at the base of her neck. "You ever notice that about her?" he said to me. "Right in here."

Tara's eyes closed and her head tilted forward, giving him access. A small sigh escaped her lips. "That feels so good."

"You gotta stretch this out or you'll lock in." His hands worked her shoulders and neck with practiced ease, and I watched her body go loose under his touch, melting into it. "I can show you tips so you can do it at home," he said to me.

He kept talking, about nutrition, about the importance of protein timing, about how body development was as much about recovery as it was about the work itself. He included me in the conversation, asking if I'd ever lifted, if I'd thought about joining them downstairs, but his eyes kept returning to Tara and most of his words were directed at her.

When we finally got up to leave, Andre stood and pulled Tara into a hug. Not a side hug or a quick squeeze, but a full embrace, his arms wrapping around her, pulling her against his chest. She disappeared into him, her arms going around his waist, and the hug lasted long enough that I found myself counting the seconds. Four, five, six.

Over her head, Andre's eyes met mine. He winked.

"See you guys around," he said when he finally let her go. "Treat her nice, now," he said to me with a grin, and he patted her ass. She didn't even notice it.

Walking home, Tara fell quiet, and I wondered if she was thinking about the hug, about his hands on her shoulders, about the way she'd melted under his touch in front of me like it was the most natural thing in the world, or about his bum pat.

Three days later I was coming home from work, climbing the stairs to our floor, when I heard voices in the stairwell again. I looked up and saw them on the landing between the second and third floors, Andre and Tara, her in workout clothes, him in his usual athletic gear.

"You feel that?" Andre was saying. His hands were on her hips, positioning her in some kind of stretch. "That's the engagement. Right there

in your glutes." He was making her balance one foot on the edge of step, the other hovering over the stairs down.

Her face was concentrated, her body angled forward with Andre's hands guiding her hips up and down. His fingers were spread wide, gripping her firmly, and I could see the pressure he was applying to her body.

They both looked up when they heard me.

"Hey Stuart," Andre called out, but he didn't remove his hands from Tara's body. He finished whatever he was showing her, his fingers pressing into her hip bones for another few seconds before he let go and stepped back. "Just getting her hips loose for some Romanian deadlift action. She keeps wanting to bend her knees too much."

"He's just very hands-on," Tara said, smiling.

"Only way to learn," Andre said. "You can talk about it all day but until you feel it with your body, it doesn't click."

We walked up the last flight together, Andre between us with an arm around each of our shoulders like we were all old friends. He was telling some story about a client at the gym who tried to bench press too much and nearly dropped the bar on his face, and Tara was laughing. I was just there, feeling the weight of his arm across my shoulders and wondering when this had become normal.

The next evening Andre knocked on our door. Tara answered and I heard her invite him in before I even saw who it was.

"I want to make a stir-fry," he said, coming into the kitchen where I was standing. "You guys have any ginger? I forgot to grab some."

"Let me check," Tara said, opening our fridge.

While she looked, Andre moved into the living room and dropped onto our couch. He sprawled out, one arm across the back, completely at ease. "You guys see that new brew pub that opened on Morrison? We got to check it out sometime."

Tara found the ginger and brought it to him, but instead of leaving, Andre stayed. He told us about the brewery, about a new workout program he was designing, about a client who was training for a triathlon. Twenty minutes passed. Tara sat next to him on the couch and I stayed in the chair across from them, mostly watching.

At one point Andre took Tara's hand, turning it over to examine her nails. "You should keep these shorter," he said, running his thumb across her fingertips. "For lifting. Long nails, you risk tearing them on the

knurling." He held her hand in both of his while he talked, his fingers moving over hers, and she watched his face as he spoke, nodding along. "But nothing sexier than long nails, got to say, right Stuart?" he said to me and he lifted her fingers to his mouth and kissed the backs of them.

When he finally left, he ruffled her hair on his way out, casual and affectionate..

The door closed and Tara came back to the couch, curling into the corner where Andre's warmth still lingered.

That night, getting ready for bed, she mentioned that Andre thought she should start taking progress photos. Track her development so she could see the changes her body was making.

"Can you take some for me?" she asked, pulling on a sports bra and leggings. "Just so I have a baseline?"

I took her phone and she posed in the bedroom mirror while I snapped photos, front, side, back. She looked at them critically, zooming in on her arms, her legs, her stomach.

"Send them to me," she said, and I texted them to her phone.

She sat on the bed and opened her messages. I watched over her shoulder as she forwarded the photos to Andre. Three dots appeared almost immediately, the typing indicator pulsing.

His response came through: a flame emoji, a flexed bicep emoji, and the words "Looking tasty!"

Tara smiled at her phone, her face soft and pleased.

I got into bed and she joined me a few minutes later, setting her phone on the nightstand. She kissed me goodnight and curled on her side, and within minutes she was asleep.

I tried to put words to what I was feeling. Every interaction with Andre could be explained. The café was a coincidence. The hands on her hips were just coaching. Borrowing ginger was neighborly. Examining her nails was practical advice. Taking progress photos was standard fitness practice.

None of it was sexual. None of it was wrong.

But something was off. Every time I thought about saying something to Tara, the words jammed up in my throat. What would I even say? Stop being friendly with the neighbor? Don't let him touch you when he's teaching you? It all sounded paranoid and controlling.

I rolled onto my side, my back to Tara, and closed my eyes. Sleep didn't come for a long time. In the darkness, all I could see was Andre's hands on

her hips, his fingers spread wide, pressing into her. His arm around her shoulders in the stairwell. Her hand in his while he examined her nails. The way she'd melted into his touch at the café, her eyes closing, that small sigh escaping her lips.

I knew something was shifting. I just didn't know how to stop it.

CHAPTER 4

Saturday afternoon we went to Meridian Books, the used bookstore on Halstead with the creaking floors and stacks that reached the water-stained ceiling. The aisles were so narrow you had to turn sideways to let someone pass, and the whole place smelled like old paper. Tara loved it there. She could spend hours running her fingers along cracked spines, pulling out random volumes to flip through.

I was in the history section when I heard his voice.

"Tara! Hey baby!"

I looked through a gap in the shelves and saw Andre coming down the aisle where Tara was browsing. He wore jeans and a fitted henley, casual but put-together in a way that made my work clothes feel even more worn.

"Andre, hi!" Tara's face brightened. "What are you doing here?"

"Just passing by, saw you through the window." He moved close to her in the narrow aisle, close enough that she had to tilt her head back to look at him. "There's a book on nutrition I've been wanting to show you.

Revolutionary approach to macros. I think they have it here."

He reached past her to scan the shelf above her head and his chest pressed against her back for a moment. She didn't step away. His arm extended over her shoulder, his body a wall of warmth behind her, and she just stood there, tilted into him.

"Yeah, here it is, I saw it last time I was in here." He pulled down a thick paperback with a minimalist cover and stepped back just enough to flip it open. Tara leaned over his arm to look at the pages, her hair falling forward. "See this chart? This is what I was telling you about. Timing windows."

His other hand came to rest on her waist, casual, natural, like it belonged there. His thumb moved against her side as he talked, a small unconscious motion that maybe he didn't even notice but I could see clearly through the gap in the shelves.

They stood that way for several minutes, his hand on her waist, her looking at the book in his hands, their heads bent together. She definitely leaned back into his hand. Finally she straightened and he let his hand fall away.

"You should get it," he said.

"It's twenty-eight dollars."

"Early progress present." He plucked it from her hands and headed toward the register before she could protest.

I moved to the end of my aisle and followed them to the front of the store. Andre paid while Tara protested weakly, and then we all walked out together into the cool afternoon.

On the sidewalk Andre pulled Tara into a hug, the kind of casual goodbye embrace friends give. But when he pulled back, he leaned down and kissed her, and not just on the cheek. It was on the corner of her mouth, his lips catching hers at an angle that could have been accidental but lasted half a second too long to be a mistake.

"See you tomorrow for legs," he said.

Tara nodded, her hand coming up to touch her mouth. "Yeah. Tomorrow."

Andre waved at both of us and headed down the street. Tara watched him go, still touching her lips, and then seemed to remember I was standing there.

"He's so generous," she said, holding up the book.

Wednesday evening Tara told me she was going down to Andre's apartment. He was making some kind of protein smoothie he wanted her to try, something with spinach and almond butter that was supposed to be good for recovery.

"You want to come?" she asked, but the invitation was perfunctory. We both knew I wouldn't.

"I've got a game" I said, gesturing vaguely at my console.

"Okay. I won't be long."

She left and I sat on the couch playing. An hour passed. Then another. I checked my phone. No messages.

When she finally came back up, her face was flushed and animated in that way it got lately whenever she'd been with Andre.

"His place is so nice," she said, dropping onto the couch next to me as though exhausted. "I know it's a basement apartment, but he's made it so

cool. Very masculine and tasteful, you know? He has this whole gallery wall of black and white photos, boxing photos, classic cars, and his furniture is all mid-century modern stuff. Really cool.”

"The smoothie was good?" I asked.

“Oh yeah, the smoothie. So good! I didn't think I'd like it but the banana makes it sweet and you can't really taste the spinach." She pulled her legs up under her, getting comfortable. "He showed me his whole meal prep system. He makes everything for the week on Sundays. He has these glass containers all lined up in his fridge, all labeled. He's very organized."

I noticed the hoodie then. Oversized, charcoal gray, with a logo for some gym on the chest. Not hers.

"New hoodie?"

She looked down like she'd forgotten she was wearing it. "Oh. I got cold down there and Andre lent it to me." She pulled the fabric up to her nose and inhaled. "It smells like his cologne. Is that weird that I notice that?" She laughed a light shrugging laugh.

"I don't know."

"I'll give it back to him tomorrow." But she didn't take it off. She curled deeper into it, drowning in the fabric, and spent the rest of the evening wrapped in something that belonged to him.

CHAPTER 5

Friday night there was an opening at the gallery on Morrison Street, the one with the exposed brick walls and concrete floors that always showed local artists nobody heard of. Tara wanted to go. She spent an hour getting ready, trying on three different outfits before settling on a black dress I'd only seen her wear once before, to a wedding two years ago. She did her makeup carefully, spending time on her eyes, and when she came out of the bedroom she looked different. Older. More sophisticated.

"You look pretty nice," I said, back footed by her stunning appearance.

"Thanks." She checked herself in the mirror by the door one more time. "Ready?"

The gallery was packed with the neighborhood's bohemian crowd, people in vintage blazers and asymmetrical haircuts, holding plastic cups of wine and talking loudly about composition and negative space. We made our way through the crowd, looking at photographs mounted on the brick walls, and I was starting to think we might get through the evening without seeing him when I heard Tara's name called.

Andre appeared with a small group of people, but when he saw Tara his attention shifted completely to her.

"Wow, you look amazing," he said, and his eyes moved over her in a way that made me aware of every curve her dress revealed. "The pic didn't do her justice," he said to me.

It was the first I heard of her taking a pic of herself for him.

Tara's face went pink. "Thanks. I wasn't sure about this dress."

"No, it's perfect." He looped his arm around her waist like it was the most natural thing in the world and started walking with her toward the far wall. I followed a step behind, suddenly feeling like a third wheel.

They stopped in front of a large black and white photograph of an empty street at dawn. Andre pulled Tara against his side and leaned down to speak into her ear. His lips brushed the shell of her ear and I saw her shiver, saw goosebumps rise on her arms.

Whatever he said made her smile. They stood that way for a long time, his arm around her, her body tucked into his side, both of them looking at the photograph. When they finally moved to the next piece, his hand slipped lower on her waist, settling just above her hip. His fingers splayed wide, claiming her, it seemed.

I was standing right there. close enough to touch them.

Andre turned to me as if suddenly remembering I existed. "What do you think, Stuart? Too pretentious or actually pretty good?"

"It's fine," I said, my voice coming out flat.

Andre laughed and squeezed Tara closer against him. "Stuart's not convinced. Fair, right? Some of this stuff is a little self-important."

We stayed another twenty minutes and then made to leave. Outside on the sidewalk, Andre pulled Tara into another hug. When he pulled back this time, he kissed her fully on the mouth. There was nothing ambiguous about it, his lips on hers for a beat, two beats, before he stepped away.

"See you tomorrow for legs," he said.

At home I waited until Tara was in the bathroom getting ready for bed, and then I forced myself to speak.

"That was... Andre kissed you. Tonight."

She came out in her pajamas, casual, like this was the most normal conversation in the world. "He's just affectionate. You know, European style he calls it."

Andre wasn't European. I knew that and she knew that.

"It seems like..." I started, but the words tangled up in my throat again. What did it seem like? What was I actually saying?

The words wouldn't come.

Tara came over and sat next to me on the bed, taking my hand in both of hers. "Stuart. He's just a friend. He's helping me get fit. That's all this is."

"But the way he..."

"You trust me, right?"

The question hung there. Did I? The answer should have been simple.

I nodded.

"He's just a friend, I promise. He's. Just a big physical man, he said he was raised by his mom with four sisters, so he's used to being around women. That's all." She kissed my cheek and stood up. "I'm going to bed. You coming?"

"In a minute."

She left and I heard her settle into bed in the next room. I sat there in the living room with all the lights off, the streetlight outside casting shadows through the window. I could still see it clearly in my mind, Andre's arm around her waist, his hand on her hip, his lips brushing her ear and then, later, pressing against her mouth.

"You look amazing," he'd said, and the way he'd looked at her when he said it left no room for interpretation.

Sunday morning we walked to the grocery store on Campbell. It was one of those clear fall days where the air had a bite to it and everyone seemed to be outside, people walking dogs, kids on scooters, the usual weekend neighborhood flow.

We were two blocks from the store when I saw Andre jogging toward us from the opposite direction. He saw us at the same moment and his face broke into that wide smile.

"Hey!" He slowed to a stop in front of us, barely winded. "Where you guys headed?"

"Grocery store," Tara said.

"I'll walk with you." He turned and fell into step beside her, and before I fully registered what was happening, his arm was around her waist, pulling her against his side. He kept her there as we walked, his hand resting just above her hip.

He turned to walk backward so he could face us while talking, something about a new training protocol he was trying, but his arm never left Tara's waist. His hand moved as he talked, sliding from her hip to the small of her back, then up to her ribcage, fingers spreading wide.

We reached a corner and stopped for a car to pass. Andre was still talking, something about periodization and recovery cycles, and while he talked his hand came up to Tara's face. He tucked a strand of her blonde hair behind her ear, I'd seen him do this before, it was becoming his signature gesture, and then let his fingers trail down the side of her neck.

Tara's eyes fluttered closed for just for a second, but I saw it.

Andre grinned at me over her head. "She's so responsive when you touch her like that. Look at her."

He said it like he was making a clinical observation, like he was explaining something about muscle fiber recruitment or heart rate zones.

Then he turned her chin toward him with one finger and kissed her on the mouth.

It was not ambiguous. His lips pressed against hers and stayed there for two seconds, three, and she leaned into it, a small sound escaping her throat. When he pulled back, she sighed, nearly stumbling forward into him.

Andre laughed. "Can't help myself around beautiful women, man. It's a problem." He shrugged at me. "And this one of yours is hot, man."

He threw his arm around my shoulder now, so both of us were bracketed by him, and he squeezed us together from behind. "You're such a lucky guy, Stuart."

Then he tugged Tara's hair, playful but firmly, and she gasped, a small, unmistakably sexual sound that made my stomach drop.

Andre laughed louder. "See? Her body is so connected. You should try tugging her hair."

He let us go and jogged off down the street, his gait easy and relaxed. I stood on the corner, frozen, my mind trying to process what just happened.

"Come on," she said. "We still need groceries."

She started walking and I followed, and neither of us said a word about it.

CHAPTER 6

The next morning I woke up to Tara already in the bathroom. I could hear the hair dryer running, which was unusual, she normally just let it air dry on weekdays. When she came out, her makeup was done with more care than usual. It was not just the basic routine, but actual effort, eye shadow, liner, the works.

She went to the dresser and started choosing her outfit, holding up two different bras to compare them in the mirror. I watched from the bed as she selected the tighter one, the one that showed more. She stepped into her leggings, the expensive ones she'd bought last month, and I noticed the underwear she'd chosen too, lacy, nicer than the cotton ones she usually wore.

There was a necklace on the dresser I didn't recognize, a delicate gold chain, small pendant. She put it on and adjusted it in the mirror.

"Where'd you get that?" I asked.

She touched it, smiling. "Andre gave it to me. He said it matches my eyes. Isn't that sweet? It was just laying around down there."

"When did he give it to you?"

"Yesterday. I forgot to mention it." She checked herself in the mirror one more time, turning to see herself from different angles. "I'm heading down for my morning session. There's coffee if you want it."

She left and I heard the door close behind her. I got up and went to the bathroom, splashed water on my face, and tried not to think about Andre fastening that necklace around her throat.

That evening Tara came home from work carrying a shopping bag from Retrograde, the vintage clothing store three blocks up. She set it on the counter with the satisfied smile of someone who'd found something good.

"Look what I got." She pulled out new workout clothes, a sports bra and leggings in matching burgundy, but tighter than anything she currently

owned. The fabric was technical, expensive-looking, the kind designed to show every line and curve.

"Andre said I should show off my progress, not hide it." She held the outfit up against herself. "What do you think?"

"It's nice. He picked it out?"

"There's more." She pulled out a small box, perfume. She opened it and sprayed a mist into the air, then walked through it. The scent was sophisticated, nothing like the sweet body spray she usually wore.

"What do you think?" She held out her wrist for me to smell.

"It's different."

"Good different?" She was watching my face. "Andre helped me pick it out. We ran into each other at lunch."

"I didn't know you saw him yesterday."

"Oh yeah, he was near my office and dropped in. We grabbed lunch together and walked around a bit." She said it casually, like it was the most natural thing in the world. "He's really easy to talk to. Like, about real things, you know?"

I didn't know what that meant, didn't know what "real things" were, or what we talked about that wasn't real.

I didn't ask.

Sunday afternoon we went to Riverside Park. We found a bench under a maple tree and sat watching the weekend crowd, families with strollers, people throwing frisbees for their dogs, someone playing acoustic guitar near the pavilion.

I saw Andre before Tara did. He was jogging on the path, shirtless, his dark skin gleaming with sweat. He saw us and changed direction, cutting across the grass toward our bench.

"Hey!" He dropped onto the bench next to Tara, breathing hard but not struggling. His arm stretched across the back of the bench behind her shoulders, and after he caught his breath, his hand dropped to rest on her shoulder. He curled her hair up in his fingers.

"Good run?" Tara asked, and she looked at him and patted his muscular bare and sweat-gleaming thigh.

"Great run. Did the whole loop, added the hill section." His hand played with her hair while he talked, wrapping a strand around his finger, letting it unwind. "You should come with me sometime. Trail running is good for cardio."

His hand moved from her hair to her neck, massaging the muscle there, then working down to her shoulder blade. She tilted her head, giving him access, and I watched his thumb work circles into her skin.

He reached across with his other hand and took her forearm, examining it the way a doctor might examine a patient. "Your muscle tone is really developing. Feel this, Stuart."

He guided my hand to Tara's upper arm. I touched her awkwardly, feeling the slight firmness there that might have been muscle or might have been nothing.

"See that definition?" Andre's hand covered mine, pressing my fingers into Tara's arm. "That's real work paying off right there."

I pulled my hand away. Andre's stayed, sliding down her forearm to her wrist, then taking her hand in both of his, turning it over to examine her palm, her fingers, like he was reading her fortune.

He leaned down and kissed the top of her head, affectionate and easy. "Gotta finish my run. Tara, see you tomorrow morning?"

"You bet."

He stood and stretched right in front of her, his body lean and powerful in the afternoon sun. Before he left, he reached down and tilted her chin up with one finger. She looked up at him now like this was expected, and he kissed her forehead, soft and deliberate, and then her mouth.

"Later gater."

He jogged off across the grass and disappeared down the path.

Tara and I sat on the bench. Around us the park continued its Sunday afternoon rhythm, dogs barking, children laughing, someone playing classic rock. My mind was racing but when I tried to grab hold of any single thought, it slipped away. The words I needed wouldn't form. Every time I reached for them, they scattered.

Tara stood up. "We should get going."

We walked home through the neighborhood, past the cafés and bookstores, past the gallery where Andre had kissed her on the mouth, past Retrograde where he'd helped her pick out perfume, apparently. I kept seeing it, his lips on her forehead, then sliding to the corner of her mouth. The way she'd tilted her face up to receive it, offering herself to him. That almost-but-not-quite kiss that was somehow worse than if it had been direct. It was the way she was natural with it now, the way she expected it.

We climbed the stairs to our third-floor apartment and Tara unlocked the door. Inside, she went to the bedroom to change and I stood in the living room, still wearing my jacket, still holding the questions I couldn't ask.

It was Thursday evening, after dinner, when I finally said something. Tara was in the bedroom getting ready to go down to Andre's apartment again. She'd put on the tight burgundy workout clothes, the ones he'd told her to buy. I could smell the perfume from the doorway, the sophisticated one he'd helped her pick out. She was doing her makeup in the mirror, taking her time with it.

"This is getting weird," I said.

She turned, mascara wand in hand, genuinely confused. "What is?"

"Andre. The way he... touches you. Kisses you."

She set down the mascara and sighed, like she'd been expecting this conversation and was disappointed it had finally arrived. She came over and sat on the edge of the bed, patient, calm.

"Stuart, we've talked about this. He's just affectionate. It's how he is with everyone."

"He doesn't kiss me like that."

"Because you're not a woman." She said it like it was obvious, reasonable. "Look, I know it might look like something, but it's not. We're friends. He's helping me. I feel better than I ever have."

I tried to find the words, tried to articulate the thing that sat wrong in my chest. "But the way he looks at you..."

"He's complimentary. Is that so bad?" She tilted her head, and there was something in her voice now, a small edge. "Should I wait to only ever hear nice things from you?"

The cut was gentle but it landed. I retreated.

"I just... I don't like it."

"You don't like that I'm getting fit? Or that I have a friend?" She was watching my face, turning my concern into something unreasonable. "That's not what I..."

But it was getting twisted, the words coming out wrong, my objection transforming into something controlling and petty.

She came over and wrapped her arms around me, pressed her face to my chest. "I love you. You know that. Andre is just a friend. That's all."

Friend. Capital F. The word she kept using like a shield.

"He doesn't want a girlfriend, he's told me that a hundred times. He's way too free a spirit he says." She pulled back and looked up at me. "Trust me. Okay?"

She kissed me softly on the lips, and I nodded because I didn't know what else to do. It sounded like they talked a lot about intimate things.

"I'll be back in a bit," she said, and then she was gone.

I sat in the apartment after she left, the space quiet without her. I turned on the TV but didn't watch it. I picked up my phone and scrolled without seeing it.

An hour passed. I checked my phone. No messages.

Another hour. The TV played a show I wasn't following. I got up and tried to read, but the words swam on the page.

It was past ten when I heard her key in the lock. She came in flushed and happy, her face bright in a way that made my chest tighten.

"Sorry, we were watching this documentary about nutrition and lost track of time." She set down her water bottle and headed straight for the bathroom. "I need to shower."

As she passed me, I saw it, a mark on her neck, just below her ear. Reddish. It could have been nothing, it could have been irritation from her collar, it could have been something else.

I didn't ask.

The next day I went down to move laundry from the washer to the dryer. The basement was quiet, the gym room empty for once. I pulled the wet clothes out and started transferring them, sorting by type the way I always did.

I found Tara's underwear, the nice set, the lacy ones I'd seen her put on that morning. I held them for a moment, about to toss it in the dryer, but then I smelled them.

There was something else on them. Cologne. Men's cologne? It was the same scent that clung to the hoodie she'd borrowed from Andre, the one she still wore sometimes around the apartment, never having given it back.

I stood there in the fluorescent light of the laundry room, holding my girlfriend's underwear, and something dark and cold formed in my stomach.

I put it in the washer with the rest of the clothes and closed the door and started the cycle and went back upstairs.

I didn't say anything.

Two days later I went for a walk after dinner, needing to clear my head. The confrontation with Tara kept playing in my mind, the way she'd turned everything around, made my concerns sound like jealousy and control. Maybe it was. Maybe I was being paranoid.

I walked through the neighborhood as the sun set, past the bookstore and the café and the gallery, all the places that were becoming landmarks in a story I didn't want to be part of. When I turned onto our street, I saw Andre's car parked outside our building and I stopped.

Tara was leaning against the passenger door. Andre stood in front of her, hands braced on either side of her against the car, boxing her in. They were talking low, intimate, their faces close together. As I watched, Andre's forehead touched hers, and they stayed that way, breathing the same air, saying nothing.

I stood across the street in the gathering dark and watched.

Andre's hand left the car and slid to her waist, pulling her against him. She came willingly, fitting herself to his body. Then they were kissing, not the brief pecks from before, but deep and hungry. His hand went into her hair, gripping, controlling the angle of her head. The kissing went on. Thirty seconds. Forty.

When they finally broke apart, Andre said something I couldn't hear and Tara laughed, swatting his chest playfully. He caught her hand and brought it to his lips, kissing her palm while his eyes stayed locked on hers. He sucked her finger into his mouth and she just stood there watching him do that with a fascination on her face.

Then he looked up and saw me across the street.

He didn't pull away. He didn't look guilty or caught. He just waved, casual and friendly as ever.

"Stuart! Just dropping Tara off. Beach trip is still on for Saturday, right?"

Like I hadn't just watched him kiss my girlfriend against his car for forty seconds.

Tara turned and saw me. Her face flushed but she didn't look guilty either, just caught, like a kid sneaking cookies before dinner.

"I'll be up in a minute, babe," she called out.

I nodded and went inside, climbed the three flights to our apartment, and unlocked the door. I went straight to the window and looked down. They were still there, talking. Andre's hands never left her waist, her arms, her

face, always touching her, and her always letting him. They talked for another five minutes before she finally pulled away and headed for the building entrance.

I moved away from the window and went to the kitchen.

When she came in, she set down her bag and found me at the sink, washing dishes.

"Beach trip?" I asked.

She looked defensive. "Yeah, Andre mentioned it at the café last week. I thought I told you."

She hadn't.

"Early morning workout on the sand. Sunrise. It'll be beautiful."

"Forty five minute drive, probably," I said.

"Yeah, so we're leaving early. Like five in the morning." She came over and put her arms around me from behind. "You can come if you want."

The invitation was hollow and we both knew it. I didn't do early mornings. Didn't do beaches. Didn't do workouts. I was the guy who worked at a warehouse and came home tired and fell asleep on the couch. I wasn't the guy who watched sunrises and did beach training with Andre.

"It's fine," I heard myself say.

She kissed my neck. "It's just exercise, babe. Fresh air. That's all."

She let go and headed for the bathroom. I heard the shower start, heard her step in. I stood at the sink with my hands in the soapy water, not moving, and Andre's words played in my head: "Just you, me, and the ocean."

I knew what was happening. I could see it clearly now, could trace the line from that first day when he'd tucked her hair behind her ear to tonight when I'd watched them kiss against his car. Every step had been small enough to accept, small enough to swallow. Each boundary crossed was just a little further than the last. Andre had been so careful, so incremental, always with plausible deniability, always with an excuse.

And every time I tried to object, Tara had an answer. Every time I tried to draw a line, it sounded paranoid in my own ears.

This is how it happens, I thought. How a man ends up somewhere impossible. One small step at a time, each one a hill too small to die on, until you're miles from where you started and you don't know the way down.

I pulled my hands from the water and dried them on a towel. From the bathroom, I could hear the shower still running. Tara was in there washing off the smell of Andre's cologne, washing away the evidence of the kiss I'd witnessed, preparing to come to bed with me and pretend everything was normal.

CHAPTER 7

I woke at 4:45 to the sound of Tara moving through the apartment, trying to be quiet but failing in the way people do when they're excited. I kept my eyes closed and listened to her footsteps, the bathroom door, water running. She'd already showered.

I opened my eyes. The bedroom was still dark, just the faint glow from the streetlight outside. I could see her silhouette moving in front of the closet, pulling on clothes. When she stepped into the light from the hallway, I saw what she was wearing, new athletic gear I'd never seen before. A sports bra in deep blue that showed the definition in her shoulders and stomach, high-waisted leggings that highlighted every curve. Expensive brands. Technical fabric. Her hair was done, pulled back in a careful ponytail. And she was wearing makeup, foundation, mascara, lip gloss, the works.

For a workout on the beach at sunrise.

She checked herself in the mirror, turning to see herself from different angles, adjusting the waistband of the leggings. She'd packed a small bag the night before, I'd watched her do it, watched her choose which clothes to bring, which towel, sunscreen, a change of clothes for after.

She glanced over and saw me awake.

"Go back to sleep, babe. I'll be back this afternoon." She came over and kissed my forehead, her lips soft and tasting faintly of mint. "Love you."

Her phone buzzed and she rushed now to grab her bag and practically ran out the bedroom. I heard the apartment door open and close, her footsteps quick on the stairs. I got up and went to the window, pulled back the curtain just enough to see.

Andre's car was parked at the curb. Tara appeared on the sidewalk below, nearly skipping to the passenger side. Andre leaned across from the driver's seat and opened her door from the inside. She climbed in and they exchanged words I couldn't hear, and then she was laughing at something he said.

The car pulled away. The taillights disappeared around the corner. The sun wasn't barely up. I saw his hand close around her upper thigh.

I tried to occupy myself. I made coffee. Sat at the kitchen table scrolling my phone, looking at nothing. Around seven I gave up and went to the café on Brennan, sat at our usual table by the window. The Saturday morning crowd filtered in around me, people with laptops, couples sharing pastries, a group of college guys loud and hungover.

My phone buzzed at 8:17 with a text from Tara. It was a photo of the beach at sunrise, the sky streaked with orange and pink, the ocean calm and reflecting the light. "So pretty here!"

I stared at the photo and tried to imagine where she was standing when she took it. It was a selfie of both of them, the sunrise behind their heads. I wondered if they'd already worked out or if they were just arriving.

I typed back: "Looks nice."

But she didn't respond.

I left the café and walked through the neighborhood without any destination past the bookstore where Andre had pressed against her back, past the gallery where he'd pulled her against his side and whispered in her ear. I ended up in Retrograde, the vintage store, wandering aimlessly through the racks of old band t-shirts and worn denim. A clerk asked if I needed help and I shook my head, left without buying anything.

Back at the apartment, I tried to read or tried to watch something. The hours passed with the particular slowness of time spent waiting. I played my game. Four o'clock came. She'd said afternoon, didn't she?. Five o'clock. Six o'clock. I started making dinner because it was easy and I could do it without thinking, and I was draining the water when I finally heard her key.

She came in like a burst of energy, glowing and windswept, her face flushed and her eyes bright. There was still sand in her hair. She dropped her bag by the door and came into the kitchen, talking fast.

"Oh my god, Stuart, it was amazing. Running on sand is so much harder than regular running, your calves burn in this completely different way. If he didn't rub me down, oh my god!"

She smiled widely. "And Andre brought all this portable equipment, resistance bands and these weight vests, and we did this whole circuit training thing right on the beach. Then we swam in the ocean and the water was so cold, like actually freezing, but it felt incredible after the workout."

She was gesturing as she talked, her hands moving to describe things I couldn't see. "And then on the way back we stopped at this little seafood shack, super rustic, just plastic tables and paper plates, you would have hated it, but the fish tacos were insane."

She never stopped smiling, not once.

I noticed the salt dried on her skin, white residue at her temples and along her collarbone. A scrape on her shoulder, red and raw.

"What's that?"

She touched it absently, glancing down like she'd forgotten it was there. "Oh, we were doing this partner exercise thing and I slipped. Andre caught me but I scraped against his watch. It's fine."

She headed toward the bathroom. "I need to shower. All this sand!"

I stood in the kitchen with the pot of pasta still in my hand, steam rising, the food I'd made getting cold. She'd been with Andre for thirteen hours. Thirteen hours of beach and body and sweat and ocean. Thirteen hours of his hands on her, positioning her, catching her, touching her. Thirteen hours of intimacy I could only imagine.

CHAPTER 8

A few days later I was coming home from work, climbing the stairs with my boots heavy and my shoulders aching from loading trucks all day. I heard voices as I reached the third-floor landing, Tara's voice, lighter and younger than it sounded with me, and Andre's deeper rumble underneath.

I turned the corner and stopped.

They were outside our apartment door. Andre had Tara pressed lightly against the wall, not aggressively but possessively, his body angled toward hers, her hips jutting out at his.

His hand was under her shirt. I could see his forearm disappearing under the fabric, moving against her stomach, sliding up to her ribs. Tara's head was tilted back against the wall, her eyes closed, a small smile on her lips, her breath in rushes.

Andre was talking low, his mouth near her ear. I caught fragments as I approached: "...feel how strong your core is getting...that's all real muscle right there."

His hand moved higher under her shirt. I could see the shape of it through the fabric cupping her breast, and she made a small sound in her throat.

Andre's other hand came up to tilt her chin toward him and he kissed her deeply, his tongue visible for a moment before their mouths sealed together. Under her shirt, his hand kneaded her breast, squeezing, and she pressed into him.

I cleared my throat.

They broke apart but not quickly, not like they were caught doing something wrong. Andre stepped back in a smooth, unhurried motion, his hand sliding out from under her shirt with deliberate slowness, taking his time, making sure I saw.

"Hey Stuart! Come here and feel Tara's muscle development in her upper body. She's made serious gains, bruh."

He was smiling, relaxed, completely comfortable.

Tara opened her eyes like she was coming out of a trance. Her breathing was fast and shallow. "Hey babe. Andre was just... we were talking about my progress."

Andre clapped me on the shoulder, friendly and familiar. "She's doing amazing. You should be proud, man."

He headed for the stairs, whistling something and disappeared down to the second floor.

Tara fumbled with her keys, wouldn't look at me. She got the door open and went straight to the bedroom, closing the door behind her. I stood in the living room with my backpack still on, the hardhat still clipped to the strap, tools clanking softly with each breath I took.

I stood there for five minutes before I could move.

That night I was in the bathroom brushing my teeth when I heard Tara's voice from the bedroom, lighter, laughing, the tone she used with him. I knew without checking that she was on the phone with Andre.

I looked at myself in the mirror. The face staring back looked tired, older than twenty-six. Worn down. Who was this person who watched another man's hand disappear under his girlfriend's shirt and said nothing? Who saw her eyes closed and her head tilted back in pleasure and cleared his throat like interrupting a minor inconvenience?

The words were right there. Stop. Don't. No. Simple words, single syllables, the kind a child could say.

But there was a wall between my brain and my mouth, solid and immovable, and the words died before they reached my lips.

I heard Tara laugh again, free and unguarded, delighted by something Andre said.

My hands gripped the edge of the sink, knuckles going white. I waited for something to happen, for my body to act, for the anger or humiliation or desperation to translate into motion.

But nothing happened. I was paralyzed.

The moment passed. I rinsed my toothbrush and put it in the holder, flossed, rinsed again, turned off the light and went to the bedroom.

Tara was on her side facing away from me, phone pressed to her ear, her voice happy and animated. "No, I can totally do that. Thursday works. Yeah, of course! What time?"

I got into bed and lay there in the dark, listening to her make plans with him, her voice bright with anticipation for whatever they were going to do

next.

CHAPTER 9

I made my decision Tuesday evening. Tara was upstairs doing something and I told her I was going for a walk. Instead I went down to the basement, to Andre's gym.

I could hear him before I saw him, the clang of metal, the grunt of exertion, music thumping from a speaker. I stood in the doorway and watched him through the mirror that covered one wall. He was doing deadlifts, the bar loaded with plates that looked impossibly heavy, his form perfect as he pulled the weight up, held it, set it down with control.

He saw me in the mirror and smiled.

"Stuart! You finally taking me up on the gym offer?" He set the bar down with a final clang and grabbed a towel, wiping his face.

I shook my head. My heart was pounding so hard I thought he might hear it. "We need to talk. About Tara."

Andre stopped. He gave me his full attention, the smile fading into something more serious. "Yeah, man. Okay. Talk." He turned the music down.

I'd rehearsed it, practiced the words in my head while lying awake at night, while driving the forklift at work, while standing in the shower. Now they felt inadequate, too small for what I needed to say.

"The way you... touch her. Kiss her. It's not... it's not appropriate."

Andre nodded slowly, his expression thoughtful. He didn't get defensive, didn't make excuses. "You know what, you're absolutely right."

I wasn't expecting agreement. The words I'd prepared next scattered. "I, what?"

He stepped closer, not threatening but direct, his eyes on mine. "You're right to feel that way. Seeing another man touch your girlfriend, kiss her, that should bother you. That's natural. That's normal. That's a good sign."

He was validating me, but something about it felt wrong like he was giving me permission to feel upset without any intention of changing his behavior.

"So you'll stop?"

Andre tilted his head, considering the question like it was more complicated than it seemed. "Man, I'm not trying to disrespect you. But Tara's her own person, you know? She's an adult. She can decide who touches her and how."

"But you..."

He held up a hand. "Look, I'll be real with you. You have every reason to feel what you're feeling. If I were you, watching what you watch, I'd be pissed. Honestly? I'd have said something long before now. But that's just me."

The implication hung there between us. You're weak for waiting this long.

"But here's the thing..." He paused.

The gym door opened. Tara came in wearing her tight workout clothes, her hair pulled back, and she stopped when she saw us both standing there.

"Oh! Stuart? What are you doing here?"

She looked between us, nervous, reading the tension in the room.

Andre went to her immediately. His arm slid around her waist like it belonged there and he pulled her against his side. While he kept talking to me, his hand slid under the back of her shirt. I could see it happening, his forearm disappearing under the fabric, moving against her skin.

Tara leaned into him. Her body language was completely comfortable with his touch, like this was normal, like this was expected.

"The thing is," Andre continued as if his hand wasn't currently under my girlfriend's shirt, "sexual health is a huge part of body development. A body like Tara's, and she's worked hard for it, it needs to be fired up regularly to function optimally."

His hand moved under her shirt and I could see the motion through the fabric. Tara's breathing changed, got shallower.

"It's just physical, Stuart. You got to trust me on this. There's no emotional component here." He kissed the top of Tara's head, tender and affectionate, while his hand worked under her clothes, sliding around the front of her body. "I have zero interest in having a girlfriend. I am way too free a spirit for that kind of tie-down."

He laughed and Tara snorted too. His hand came out from under her shirt and went to her neck, massaging her deeply, his fingers working into

the muscle with practiced skill. Tara's eyes fluttered closed and she melted into his touch.

Andre looked at me while his hands worked over Tara's body. "She's getting the physical touch and validation her body needs, and it's making her healthier. And you benefit from that, right? She tells me what you guys do in bed. That's good, right?"

I stood in the doorway of the gym, the confrontation having somehow gotten completely away from me. I came here to stop this. To draw a line. To tell him to back off. Now I was watching him touch her while he explained why it was actually good for everyone involved.

"I gotta go," I finally managed.

"Sure, man. We're good though, right?" Andre's tone made it clear it wasn't really a question.

I turned and walked out. Behind me I heard Tara's voice, small and breathy: "That feels so good..."

I couldn't tell if she was talking about the massage or something else.

I walked the neighborhood aimlessly as evening fell and the streetlights came on. I ended up on a bench in the park, now mostly empty except for a few dog walkers and someone packing up from a picnic. I sat there and tried to process what just happened.

I'd gone down there to confront Andre. To stop it. To finally do something. Somehow I'd left with his permission to feel upset but with nothing changed. Nothing stopped. He was going to keep touching her, keep kissing her, keep doing whatever he wanted because Tara was "her own person" and this was all just "physical" and "sexual health."

His words echoed in my head: "Sexual health... just physical... trust me... no emotional component."

How do you argue with that? How do you fight someone who agrees you should be upset but keeps doing it anyway? Who validates your feelings while touching her in front of you?

I sat on that bench as darkness fell completely and understood that Andre was better at this than I was at stopping it.

A week later, Friday night, I was in the living room when I heard music coming from the bedroom. It wasn't workout music but something with a heavy beat, something you'd hear in a nightclub. I went to the doorway and watched Tara trying on outfits, holding up different dresses to her body in the mirror.

She settled on a black dress I'd never seen before, short and tight and shimmery, with thin straps that looked like they might snap if pulled too hard. It was completely unlike anything she'd ever worn.

"Andre's taking me out. There's this club he thinks we should go to."

She said it casually, matter-of-fact, like she was telling me about a trip to the grocery store.

"A club?" My voice sounded distant, like it was coming from someone else.

"Yeah! He says I should show off my new body. Celebrate the progress!" She was doing her makeup now, dramatic smoky eyes, dark lipstick, winged eyeliner. She was taking her time with it, getting it perfect. She wore jewelry that caught the light, pieces I didn't recognize. She looked stunning. Sophisticated. And sexual. She looked like a stranger.

"I thought we could..." I started.

"Oh babe, you hate clubs. You always say that. Too loud, too crowded, remember?"

She was right. I had said that. Many times over the four years we'd been together.

"But..."

"It's just dancing. Andre's really into the scene. He knows all the good spots. It'll be fun!" She leaned close to kiss the air in front of my cheek so as not to ruin her fresh make up.

She was ready now. She looked at herself in the full-length mirror, turned to check herself from different angles, and whatever she saw satisfied her. She grabbed the perfume, the expensive one Andre helped her pick out, and sprayed it. The scent filled the bedroom, filled the hallway where I stood.

She grabbed a small clutch purse and kissed me quickly. Her dark lipstick left a mark on my cheek. "Don't wait up!"

Then she was gone, a swirl of perfume and clicking heels on the stairs and the door closing and silence. She was wearing ridiculous platform pumps she could barely get down the stairs in. How was she going to dance in them?

I stood in the empty apartment. Her music was still playing in the bedroom. I went in and turned it off.

I went to the window and watched them drive away. Through the car window I could see Andre's hand on her bare thigh, possessive and familiar.

She leaned toward him, laughing at something he said and I could see her stretch to kiss him. The car turned the corner and they were gone.

I tried to stay awake. I made it until midnight watching something on TV that I couldn't have described if asked. My eyes got heavy and I dozed off on the couch.

I woke to her key in the door. I grabbed my phone: it was 2:47am.

She came in carefully, trying to be quiet, and saw me awake on the couch.

"Oh! Sorry, didn't mean to wake you!"

She was disheveled in a specific way, her hair messy but not wind-messy, makeup smudged, the black dress askew with one strap falling off her shoulder. She smelled like sweat and alcohol and men's cologne. Andre's cologne. And something else underneath, something primal and unmistakable.

There was a hickey on her collarbone, visible and fresh. She wasn't trying to hide it.

I stared at it and she noticed me staring. Her hand came up to touch it but she didn't cover it.

"It's so crowded in those places, people just..." She trailed off, didn't finish the excuse, didn't even try to make it believable. "It's wild."

"Did you have fun?" I heard myself ask. the question sounded absurd even as the words left my mouth.

She nodded and smiled, genuine pleasure on her face. "Yes!. Andre's a really good dancer. He knows everyone. We got into this VIP section..."

She described the club, the music, the scene, the people she met. She never mentioned how she got the hickey and I didn't ask.

"I need to shower," she finally said, and headed for the bathroom.

I sat in the dark living room listening to the water run. She was in there for a long time, washing off the night, washing off Andre, washing off whatever had happened in that VIP section that left marks on her skin.

I sat there at 3am in the dark and thought about how this kept happening, kept escalating, kept becoming more impossible to stop. Andre's hand under her shirt in the gym while he explained sexual health. The hickey on her collarbone that she didn't bother to hide. The way she'd looked in that dress, transformed into someone I didn't recognize.

CHAPTER 10

I woke up in bed with no memory of getting there. The last thing I remembered was sitting on the couch at 3am listening to Tara shower. At some point I must have moved to the bedroom, collapsed onto the mattress. Tara's side was empty, the sheets already cool.

I found her in the kitchen looking tired but content in a way that made my chest tight. She was wearing Andre's hoodie, the charcoal gray one he'd lent her weeks ago. The fabric swallowed her small frame, the sleeves hanging past her hands.

I sat at the table and watched her make coffee. The hickey on her collarbone was even more visible in the morning light, dark purple-red, the size of a quarter, positioned right where her shirt collar would normally cover it. She didn't try to hide it. She moved around the kitchen with it on full display.

I wanted to ask about the hickey, about where they went after the club, about what happened in that VIP section. The words formed in my throat and died there.

"Are you going to keep going out with him?"

She turned, surprised. "I mean, yeah? It's fun. I never get to do stuff like that."

The implication hung between us: I never get to do stuff like that with you.

She brought me coffee and kissed the top of my head, her lips barely touching my hair. "Don't worry so much, babe."

The dismissal was casual, complete, like my concern was unnecessary or silly or both.

That night she initiated sex with me. She'd been doing that more frequently over the past few weeks, but tonight was different. She pushed me back on the bed the moment we got in there, straddled me, took control in a way she never had before. Her movements were confident, practiced, like she'd choreographed this.

Then she slid down my body and took me in her mouth.

She'd done this maybe once before, years ago, awkward and half-hearted, clearly not enjoying it. Now she did it with skill and enthusiasm that spoke of practice. She knew exactly what to do, how to move her tongue, where to apply pressure, the rhythm that worked. I was shocked and overwhelmed and aroused despite the confusion flooding my brain. Of course I said nothing about it.

After, she straddled me and guided me inside her, riding me with her body moving in ways I didn't know she could move. The angles she found, the rhythm she set, the way she used her hips, all of it felt practiced, rehearsed, like she'd been trained.

It was the best sex we'd ever had and I knew it had nothing to do with me.

When it was over she curled against me, satisfied and sated. My mind was racing, thoughts tumbling over each other.

"That was... where did you learn..." The question escaped before I could stop it.

She laughed, sleepy and unbothered. "I've been reading stuff, dummy. Watching videos. I wanted to surprise you. Sexual health, right?" She laughed into my neck.

CHAPTER 11

Her phone was on the nightstand. Earlier when she'd been texting I'd seen the notification count: 23 unread messages from Andre.

The next evening I worked up the courage. I practiced what I'd say while loading trucks, while driving home, while walking up the stairs. Tara was cooking dinner when I finally spoke, the apartment filled with the smell of garlic and tomatoes.

"Last night was different."

She didn't turn around, kept stirring the sauce. "Good different, I hope?" Her voice was light and casual.

"Yeah, but... I mean, we've never..."

How do I say this? How do I ask if another man taught her how to fuck?

She turned and leaned against the counter, wooden spoon still in hand. She looked at me directly. "Stuart. I'm becoming a different person. A better version of myself. Is it so weird that includes our sex life?"

"Did Andre..." I couldn't finish the sentence. The words lodged in my throat.

She sighed, not defensively, just matter-of-factly. "Andre talks about everything. Fitness, nutrition, mental health, sexual health, it's all connected. Body and mind. He's given me some pointers. So what?"

My stomach dropped, that free-fall feeling I was getting used to.

"Pointers?"

She nodded. "Tips. Techniques. Things guys like. What works." She lifted her eyes to mine. "I think he was right about most of it, don't you?"

She said it like she was talking about meal prep or workout routines. Clinical. Simple. No different than discussing proper squat form.

"He's very experienced. You enjoyed it, admit it!" She slapped my arm like we were talking about cooking or something.

I couldn't deny it though.

She touched my face gently. "Isn't this what you wanted too? Me being more confident? More adventurous? Better at this?" She clutched me in the

groin.

She kissed me softly and went back to stirring the sauce like the conversation was over, like she hadn't just admitted another man was teaching her how to have better sex.

I sat at the table, reeling.

That weekend we went shopping together, a rare occurrence now that she was gone so much. We ended up in Retrograde, the vintage store, and Tara was looking at dresses when Andre walked in.

"Hey you two!" It was his usual big greeting, huge smile, like running into us was the best part of his day.

He gravitated to Tara immediately and took over, pulling clothes from racks and holding them up. "This would look incredible on you. And this. Oh, definitely this."

He held up a dress, very short, very low cut, black with a plunging neckline that would show everything.

Tara hesitated, looked at the price tag, looked at me.

"Trust me on this one," Andre said, and took her hand, leading her to the dressing rooms in the back.

I stood in the store waiting. They were back there a long time, five minutes, then ten. I could hear her voice, Andre's laughter, the sound of a zipper being pulled.

When they finally emerged, she was wearing the dress. Andre had his hands on her hips, turning her to face the full-length mirror mounted on the wall.

"See? Perfect. Told you."

His hands roamed her body while he talked, waist, hips, sliding up her ribs. She was watching him in the mirror, not watching herself, watching his hands on her body. He was showing her body to me to get my approval.

But his hands cupped her breasts from behind, adjusting the fit of the dress, the way the neckline sat right there in the store. I was ten feet away. The clerk glanced up, looked away quickly, went back to their phone.

"You have to get this, Tara. Stuart, tell her."

My voice came out flat and distant. "It looks good."

Andre's hands slid down to her thighs and tugged the hem down where it had ridden up. "Wear this one for me next time we go out, it's that hot on you, baby."

It was a command, not a suggestion and she nodded.

Andre kissed her neck, her bare shoulder. His hand slipped up her inner thigh and I could see it disappearing under the dress hem. Tara gasped softly.

Andre grinned at me in the mirror, maintaining eye contact. "Her body is so responsive. I keep telling her that. It's a gift."

Tara went back to change and Andre came over to me, threw his arm around my neck in a gesture that was brotherly and casual and possessive all at once.

"She's looking good, right? You're welcome."

That phrase again. The one that made my skin crawl.

"For what?"

Andre pulled back and looked at me like the answer was obvious. "For bringing her out. For teaching her. For making her into someone way out of your league, man." He spoke quiet and privately to make clear what he was talking about.

And he said it with a laugh, like it was a joke between friends. But his eyes stayed locked on mine.

"Look at her. When she's with me, dressed like that, moving like that, she could have anyone. Anyone she wants."

Tara came back in her regular clothes, holding the dress. "I'm getting it."

"Atta girl," Andre said, and he paid for it before she could object. "My treat. I'm gonna love taking that around," he said over his shoulder at me.

We walked home through the neighborhood, Tara carrying the shopping bag with black tissue paper visible at the top. She was texting and I didn't need to look to know it was Andre. I could tell by the small smile on her face, the way she bit her lower lip while typing.

"He wants me to come down tonight. Watch a documentary about muscle recovery and proteins."

I stopped walking in the middle of the sidewalk.

"Tara."

She looked up from her phone, annoyed at the interruption. "What?"

"This has to stop."

"What has to stop?" Her voice was level, challenging.

"You know what."

She stepped closer to me. People flowed around us on the sidewalk, giving us space.

"Say it, Stuart. Tell me exactly what you think is happening."

My words jammed up. Everything I wanted to say, needed to say, piled up behind my teeth and wouldn't come out. My throat closed. My mouth wouldn't open.

She waited. Five seconds. Ten. Nothing came.

She shook her head, disappointed but not surprised. "That's what I thought."

She started walking again. I followed after a moment, mute and defeated.

We reached our building and she stopped at the entrance.

"I'm going down to Andre's now actually. Don't wait up."

She kissed my cheek, casual, dismissive, the way you'd kiss a roommate or a brother. Then she went inside and headed for the basement stairs without looking back.

I stood on the sidewalk and watched through the glass door as she descended out of sight.

After a while I went inside and climbed the three flights to our empty apartment, my footsteps echoing in the stairwell.

She came back up at midnight and dove right into the shower. I pretended to be sleeping.

CHAPTER 12

Andre invited us both down for dinner on a Thursday evening. He texted Tara, who said yes immediately without asking me. I found myself sitting in his basement apartment that evening, taking in how different it was from our cluttered place upstairs.

The space was masculine but curated, a leather couch that looked expensive, industrial shelving with carefully arranged books and equipment, good lighting that made everything look warm. Framed prints covered the walls, athletes in motion and cityscapes at night. The whole place smelled like sandalwood and clean laundry.

Andre cooked in the open kitchen while we sat at his small dining table. He made pasta from scratch, sauce with fresh tomatoes and basil, garlic bread that filled the apartment with its smell. Hip hop played from speakers I couldn't see, something sophisticated and smooth. He poured wine freely, topping off glasses before they got low.

Tara was completely comfortable here. She knew where the wine glasses were, where he kept the bottle opener, moved around his space with the ease of familiarity.

The food was really good. Andre could cook, not just heat things up or follow simple recipes.

After dinner we moved to the couch. Andre put on a documentary something foreign with subtitles that I couldn't follow. He sat in the middle, Tara on his right, me on his left. His arm went around her naturally and pulled her close to him.

His hand slid down from her shoulder, casual at first, just resting on her side. Then it went lower, and as I watched from the corner of my eye, it slid under the waistband of her jeans. Though it was dark, I could see the shape of his hand working down into her pants.

Tara shifted and parted her legs. Andre's hand disappeared further and I knew exactly where it was now. He was over her underwear, touching her.

He kept talking about the documentary, commenting on the info, like nothing unusual was happening. But his arm was moving rhythmically in small, steady movements as though nobody could see.

Tara's breathing changed and got shallower and faster. She was trying to stay composed, trying to act normal, but her body betrayed her. Her hand gripped Andre's thigh.

Andre looked over at me and grinned, casual and friendly. "Your girlfriend, she gets so wet, man. It's crazy. Like, instantly." He said it privately like she wouldn't be able to hear, sitting right beside him.

Tara whimpered, a small sound that cut through the dialogue.

Andre's hand worked faster. I could see the movement of his forearm, could see Tara starting to squirm against him.

"Feel how she's moving?" Andre laughed, delighted by it. "She can't help it."

I sat frozen three feet away, watching my girlfriend being fingered on another man's couch.

Tara's head fell back against the cushions and small sounds escaped her throat. Her hips were moving now, grinding against his hand.

"You want I should stop?" Andre looked directly at me, asking permission, mocking me with the question.

I couldn't speak. My throat had dried up completely.

"No, right? It's hot, isn't it." He kept going, his fingers working inside her.

Tara got louder. She couldn't stay quiet anymore. Her whole body moved with it now, chasing the sensation.

"Yeah baby," Andre said.

She tried to muffle herself but couldn't, and a cry broke out of her. Her whole body shuddered.

Andre pulled his hand out slowly. He held it up in the lamplight, his fingers glistening wet. He made sure I saw.

"See that?"

He sucked them in his mouth.

Tara slumped against him, trembling and boneless. Andre kissed the top of her head.

"You good now, ain't you?"

She nodded weakly, but couldn't speak yet.

I stood up. The chair scraped against his floor. "I gotta go."

My voice sounded distant, like it was coming from somewhere else.

Tara barely registered that I'd spoken. She was lost in the afterglow, her eyes half-closed.

"Alright man, see you around. Thanks for coming down." Andre said it like I'd just stopped by for coffee.

I climbed the stairs to our apartment with my legs shaking.

I sat in the living room in the dark. I couldn't move to the bedroom, couldn't make myself move. I just sat there on the couch.

Hours later I heard her key in the lock. I checked my phone: 12:17am.

She came in quietly and saw me sitting in the dark. She didn't seem surprised.

"You waited up for me?"

She came over and sat next to me on the couch where I'd been sitting. She smelled like sex, like Andre's cologne, like sweat and skin.

"Are you going to be okay?" she asked.

The question was absurd.

I looked at her. "What's happening to us?"

She took my hand. Her hand was soft and warm, the same hand I'd held for four years.

"Nothing is happening to us. I'm just... exploring. Growing. Andre helps me feel things I didn't know I could feel."

"In front of me."

She considered this. "You could've left. You don't have to watch. Andre said he thinks you liked it. Did you like it?"

I couldn't talk.

She kissed my cheek, gentle and almost pitying. "I still love you. This doesn't change that. It's just fitness."

She got up and went to the bathroom. I heard the water run. She was washing Andre off her skin, but when she came out and got into bed, I could still smell it on her.

CHAPTER 13

The next evening I came home from work at the normal time and found Tara in the bedroom packing an overnight bag, the small duffel she used for weekend trips.

"What are you doing?" I already knew but didn't want to know.

"Oh, I'm staying down at Andre's tonight. We're doing an early morning training session tomorrow at the beach again and it's just easier. We're going to film ourselves!"

She said it like it was the most normal thing in the world, like girlfriends did this, slept at other men's apartments.

"You're sleeping down there?"

"On his couch probably. We usually fall asleep watching something anyway."

She zipped the bag and came over to kiss me like she was heading to the grocery store.

"I'll be back up tomorrow."

She picked up the bag and left.

I stood in the apartment after she was gone. I went to her drawer and found that most of her nice underwear was gone, the lacy ones, the matching sets. I looked in the bathroom and saw that her good makeup was missing, along with the expensive face cream and the perfume Andre helped her pick out.

She didn't pack for a couch and not for just sleeping, either.

Saturday morning I went to the café alone, the one where we used to go together every weekend. I sat at our usual table by the window and ordered coffee, black with no sugar.

A text came from Tara.

It was a photo of her and Andre, his arm was around her from behind, both of them in workout clothes, both sweaty and happy. Her head was tilted back against his chest. His face was pressed to her neck. They were in

his apartment, I recognized the background, the industrial shelving, the framed prints.

"Good morning sleepy!"

I stared at the photo and zoomed in. Her hair was messy the way it got messy in bed, not from working out.

They didn't just work out. I knew exactly what they did before they worked out, after they worked out, instead of working out.

I set the phone down and drank my coffee. It had gone cold.

I didn't reply to the text.

I walked home through the neighborhood in the late morning sun, passing the bookstore. Everything was different now. The whole neighborhood felt contaminated, like every corner held a memory I didn't want. I didn't belong in these places anymore.

CHAPTER 14

I got off work early on a Tuesday. The supervisor sent us home around two, the delivery truck never showed, nothing to unload, take the afternoon. I climbed the stairs to our apartment in the middle of the day, a time when I was never usually home.

As I reached the third floor landing, I heard music coming from inside, something with a heavy bass line, unusual for daytime

I unlocked the door quietly, not trying to sneak in but not announcing myself either.

The living room was empty. Tara's purse sat on the table. Andre's jacket hung on the back of a chair.

The music came from the bedroom, and underneath it I could hear other sounds.

I walked down the short hallway. The bedroom door was ajar.

Through the gap I saw Andre sitting on the edge of our bed, still dressed in athletic shorts and a tank top. Tara was kneeling on the floor between his legs wearing just a t-shirt, her underwear gone. Her head moved up and down. His hand was buried in her long blonde hair, guiding her, controlling her rhythm.

His head was tilted back, eyes closed. "That's it... just like that... good girl..."

Tara made a wet sound, enthusiastic and eager.

Andre groaned softly and his hand tightened in her hair, holding her down.

I stood frozen in the hallway of my own apartment. I couldn't move, couldn't speak, couldn't even breathe.

Andre's eyes opened and he saw me standing there.

He didn't stop. He didn't push Tara away. He just smiled, lazy and satisfied.

"Hey man. You're home early."

He kept Tara's head where it was though she froze when she heard him mention me and started to pull back. But Andre's hand held her in place, firm and unyielding.

"Don't stop baby."

To me, conversationally: "Your girl gives incredible head. Did you know that?"

Tara made a protesting sound but didn't actually stop. She obeyed Andre.

"She's been practicing. Really dedicating herself to it. Shows real commitment."

I couldn't move. I was paralyzed in my own hallway.

Andre's breathing quickened. His other hand joined the first in her hair.

"You don't mind, right? If you minded, you'd say something."

I said nothing. Words didn't exist anymore.

Andre smiled wider. "Yeah."

His head fell back. He was close. I watched. I couldn't look away, couldn't make myself leave.

Andre finished, I could tell from the way his whole body tensed, from the guttural sound he made.

Tara sat back on her heels and wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. She finally looked at me. Her eyes were glazed and defiant, and something else too. Pride, maybe.

Andre pulled her up by the hair, not rough but dominant, and kissed her deeply. I could see his tongue.

"Such a good girl," he said again. "You swallowed it all this time," he said and he squeezed her cheeks to make her mouth drop open in front of his eyes.

Then to me, casual: "We were just... you know. Heat of the moment thing." He grinned. "I should probably go. Let you guys have your evening."

He walked past me in the hallway and paused to clap my shoulder. "See you around, man."

He left and the apartment door closed.

Tara sat on the bed. I stood in the doorway. Neither of us spoke for a long time.

Finally she said, "Are you going to say something?"

My mouth opened but nothing came out.

She got up and went to the bathroom, shutting the door. I heard the sink run. She was rinsing her mouth.

I walked to the living room and sat on the couch and stared at nothing.

CHAPTER 15

The next day, Saturday, Tara went out to run errands. I was putting away laundry, a task that had fallen to me because she didn't do it anymore. Too busy with making clips for their web project.

I was folding clothes and putting them in drawers when I found her clothes from the club last week, the short black dress Andre had bought her. I picked it up to put it away.

Something fell out of a hidden pocket. A condom wrapper. Empty.

I stood there holding it. She was on birth control and had been for years. We didn't use condoms. Hadn't used them since the first few months we were together, four years ago.

This wasn't for me.

I looked at the wrapper. Trojan. Magnum. Large.

I put it in the trash and sat on the bathroom floor, the cold tile against my back. I stared at the opposite wall.

After a while I got up. Time had passed but I didn't know how much.

I finished the laundry.

Sunday afternoon I was walking through the park. I needed air, needed to move, needed something.

I saw them across the green, on a blanket under a tree far away and by themselves. They had a picnic setup, basket, wine bottle, cheese and bread. They hadn't seen me. I was too far away, partially hidden by other trees.

Andre was on his back with his arms behind his head. Tara straddled him. They were clothed but the movement was unmistakable, she was grinding on him, rolling her hips, dry humping him in the park. His hands slid under her shirt and her back arched. She was in a wide bright sundress.

They were kissing then, deep and hungry, their tongues visible even from that distance.

His hand slid up under the dress and I could see it working, could see her start to move differently, rocking against his hand.

They were in public. It was a Sunday afternoon. There were families here. Dog walkers. Joggers.

They didn't care.

Andre rolled her onto her back on the blanket and covered her with his body. His hand disappeared and Tara's legs parted.

I watched my girlfriend being brought to orgasm in a public park on a Sunday afternoon.

She cried out, tried to muffle it, but the sound carried, soft but audible in the bright sunshine.

Andre looked around then, casual, checking who might have heard. His eyes passed right over where I was standing. He saw me, recognition flashed across his face.

He waved like we were neighbors running into each other.

Tara didn't see me, her eyes were closed, lost in the sensation.

Andre grinned and kept his hand working on her.

I turned and walked away. I left the park.

Tara came home that evening around seven. She was glowing and happy and windswept. I was making dinner.

She came up behind me and wrapped her arms around me. "Hey babe."

I didn't turn around. I kept stirring the sauce.

"I saw you today. At the park."

She stiffened and pulled back. Long pause.

"Oh." Another pause. "So you saw us."

Not a question.

"Yeah."

I was still stirring, watching the sauce move in circles.

She leaned against the counter next to the stove. "And?"

"And what?"

I finally looked at her.

"What do you want me to say, Stuart?" Her voice wasn't defensive. Just tired. Like this was inevitable, like she'd been waiting for this.

I looked at her now. "I want you to explain. I want you to tell me why you're fucking him."

She didn't flinch at the word. Didn't look away.

"I'm not fucking him."

"Everything but."

"Does it matter?" Her voice was quiet now.

"So why not just... leave me? Be with him?"

The question came out smaller than I intended.

She shook her head. "I told you. He doesn't want a relationship. And I love you, Stuart."

"This is love?" I gestured vaguely at the apartment, at us, at everything.

"It's not about love. What we have is love. What I have with Andre is... something else." She was trying to find words.

"What?"

She thought about it. "He makes me feel alive in a way I've never felt. Powerful. Desired. Sexual."

Pause.

"And I don't."

She came to me and took my face in her hands, gentle and almost tender. "You make me feel safe. Loved. Stable. That matters too. That's important. He could never give me that," she said and she laughed to herself at the very idea.

She kissed me softly. "I don't want to lose you."

"Then stop."

She pulled back and looked at me. "I can't."

The honesty was brutal and clean.

"I don't want to."

She went to the bedroom and closed the door.

I stood at the stove and turned off the heat. Neither of us was hungry anymore.

I served myself dinner and ate alone at the table, not tasting anything. In the bedroom, light from Tara's phone glowed under the door. I could hear her occasional quiet laugh as she texted, and I knew without looking that she was talking to him.

CHAPTER 16

I woke up to an empty bed. I could hear voices from the living room.

I got up and pulled on sweatpants, walked out to find Andre sprawled on our couch in just athletic shorts and a tank top, barefoot, completely comfortable and at home. Tara was in the kitchen making breakfast, eggs, bacon, toast. She wore just my old t-shirt and underwear, the shirt barely covering her.

"Morning babe!" she called out cheerfully when she saw me.

Andre looked over from the couch. "Stuart, my man. Tara makes killer eggs. You're a lucky guy."

I stood in the doorway of my own living room, trying to process what I was seeing.

"What are you doing here?"

The question came out flat.

Andre stretched, completely relaxed. "She wanted to cook for me, bro." Tara brought Andre a plate, full breakfast. She sat next to him on the couch and curled into his side. He fed her a bite of eggs, his hand resting on her bare thigh.

I went to the kitchen and poured coffee. My hands were shaking.

They were talking and laughing about something from some documentary. Andre's hand slid up Tara's leg, under the t-shirt. I was ten feet away, making coffee, getting ready for work. It was her day off.

Andre kissed Tara's neck and she sighed.

"Andre..." A soft protest. "Stuart's right here." She laughed privately.

Andre didn't stop though. "He doesn't care. Do you, Stuart? Do you care?"

I was pouring coffee. I didn't answer.

Andre pulled Tara onto his lap. She went willingly. She was facing me now, straddling Andre on the couch. His hands roamed her body freely, sliding under her t-shirt. She wasn't wearing a bra. I could see his hands moving under the fabric, shaping over her breasts, teasing her erect nipples.

Tara's eyes met mine across the room. There was a question in them, maybe a challenge, maybe asking permission, maybe asking me to stop this.

I looked away and finished my coffee, rinsed the cup.

"I have to go to work."

Tara was breathless. "Okay babe. Have a good day."

It was like everything was normal, like her boyfriend wasn't about to leave her half-naked on another man's lap.

I left them there and closed the door. I stood in the hallway for a moment. I could already hear sounds starting through the door.

At work I tried to function. I worked at a loading dock in a warehouse distribution center, forklifts and pallets and heavy boxes, physical labor that usually helped keep my mind occupied.

But not today. I couldn't focus. I kept thinking about them in my apartment, in my living room, on my couch.

At lunch I checked my phone. No messages. I sat alone in the break room with vending machine coffee and a sandwich. I couldn't eat it.

Martinez, a friendly guy who worked the forklift, sat down across from me. "You okay, man? You seem off lately."

"Yeah, fine."

"You sure? You've been quiet. Lost weight."

I looked down. Had I? I hadn't noticed.

"I'm fine. Just tired."

"You need to talk about anything..." Martinez offered.

I shook my head. What would I even say? How would I explain?

Martinez let it go.

I sat there with my coffee going cold and my sandwich uneaten. My hands shook when I picked up the cup. I couldn't let this go on, I had to do something.

CHAPTER 17

I came home from work at the normal time, around six. Tara was there, dressed up in a clubbing outfit, the short black dress Andre had bought her. Full makeup. Her hair was done, too dramatic and sexual.

"Going out?" I asked, already knowing the answer.

She shook her head. "No. Andre's coming up. We're staying in tonight. He wanted me to dress up."

Something in her tone was different, decisive and final.

The door opened. Andre had a key now. When did that happen? It didn't matter.

He came in with a bottle of wine. "Evening, folks."

He kissed Tara immediately, deep and long.

He opened the wine and poured three glasses. We sat in the living room on couch and chair, a triangle. Conversation was light and surface, but the tension was thick and palpable and electric. We circled things, me waiting for my opening.

Andre's hands were on Tara constantly, her thigh, her neck, her hair, never not touching her.

After one glass, Andre set his down. "Tara, come here."

It was a command, not a request.

She went to him without hesitation. He pulled her onto his lap, facing me, and started undressing her slowly in front of me. Each piece of clothing was removed while I watched. Zipper. Straps. Fabric sliding. Clasps opened.

Tara didn't resist and didn't help. She just let it happen, let him undress her passively.

Soon she was naked completely on Andre's lap in my living room under the lamp light, every inch of her visible.

Andre touched her everywhere. His fingers slid between her legs. She gasped and parted her thighs, giving him more.

"Look at her, Stuart," Andre said, his voice low and commanding. "Look how wet she gets for me."

Andre worked her with his fingers. She was panting and moving, grinding down on his hand.

"She's so fucking responsive. Every single time. It's incredible."

Tara shook and cried out. Andre pulled his fingers out and held them up.

"Delicious."

He shifted Tara off his lap and stood. He started undressing himself, slow and confident.

Tara watched, hungry and needy, biting her lip, reaching her toes out to touch him where she could reach.

Andre turned to me and looked at me directly. "Let me ask you something, man."

He pulled off his shirt, revealing all his muscle and power. "You get aroused by it? Watching me do your girlfriend?"

I held my powder.

"It's okay to admit it. I can see you do. You are right now, too." He dropped his pants, then his boxer briefs. He stood there fully erect and fully exposed, everything visible. "It's natural, bud, watching another more powerful man take what's yours. There's something primal about it. Evolutionary. You realize it's the way it is."

Tara was staring at Andre's body openly and hungrily, biting her lip harder.

"So here's what's going to go down." Andre stepped toward Tara. "I'm going to fuck her now. And I mean really fuck her. And you can watch or not, your call."

He pulled Tara up from the couch. She was already writhing at the prospect. He kissed her deeply with his tongue and his hands drove through her hair. When he broke the kiss, he said, "You ready?"

Tara nodded, breathless. "Not you, baby, I was asking your boyfriend."

What did I do? You know what I did. I turned my chair, sipped my wine, and watched him do her all the way on our bed.